GLUTEN-FREE CRUMB CRUST

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	TOTAL TIME	OVEN
1 pie shell at 23 cm, or 1 cheesecake base at 25 cm	**10 min**	**about 30 min plus cooling**	**350F / 180C for 5 to 10 min**

INGREDIENTS

150 g	Oat digestive biscuits, baked and cooled
4 tbsp	Unsalted butter, melted
1 tbsp + 2 tsp	Brown sugar
1/2 tsp	Salt
1 tsp	Cinnamon, optional

METHOD

1. Bake a batch of oat digestive biscuits ahead and let them cool completely.
2. Heat the oven to 350F.
3. Grind the biscuits to a fine crumb in a food processor, about 30 seconds.
4. Pour the melted butter over the crumbs in an even stream, then add the brown sugar, the salt and the cinnamon if you are using it.
5. Run the processor about 10 seconds more. Stop once a handful of the mixture clumps when you squeeze it in your palm.
6. Tip the crumbs into a pie pan or a springform and press them evenly across the bottom and up the sides.
7. Pack them down firmly with the flat base of a cup.
8. Bake 5 to 10 minutes, until golden brown.
9. Cool the shell completely before any filling goes in.

NOTES

150 g of biscuit works out to roughly 10 of them.
Butter, sugar, salt and cinnamon are all given by volume, with no weights alongside.
The crust is gluten-free because the biscuits are. They are built on rolled oats and oat flour with no wheat, so use certified oats if that matters.
The squeeze test in step 5 is the one that decides the outcome. Crumbs that will not clump bake into a shell that collapses when you cut it.

PRESERVING

A pressed and baked shell is sturdier than it looks, but it draws moisture from the air and from any filling.
The baked shell keeps covered in the fridge up to 2 days before filling.
Keep it cold rather than at room temperature, because the butter is what holds the crumb together.
Fill it only once it is cold all the way through.
The biscuits themselves hold a week airtight, so make them well in advance.

BASE

Oat Digestive Biscuits

Makes: 24 cookies / Active Time: 25 min / Total Time: about 45 min / Oven: 350F / 180C for 14 min

INGREDIENTS

45 ml	Milk
1 tsp	Molasses
300 g	Rolled oats
80 g	Oat flour
70 g	Dark brown sugar
1 tsp	Salt
1/2 tsp	Baking soda
170 g	Unsalted butter, cold

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F. Line a baking sheet with parchment or a nonstick liner.
2. Stir the milk and molasses together in a small bowl.
3. Cut the butter into 6 mm cubes.
4. In a food processor, grind the rolled oats to a fine meal. Follow with the oat flour, then the brown sugar, the salt and the baking soda, and run it until the mix looks even. Drop in the butter and process to a sandy texture. Pour in the milk and molasses and process just until the dough starts pulling together.
5. By hand, grind the oats fine in a spice grinder or blender. Tip them into a large bowl, add the oat flour, then the brown sugar, the salt and the baking soda, and whisk it all even. Rub the butter in with your fingers until the mixture is sandy. Add the milk and molasses and bring it together with a spatula, stopping as soon as it starts to hold.
6. Turn the dough onto a work surface and knead it a few times into one cohesive mass.
7. Take a tablespoon of dough at a time, roll it into a ball between your palms, and press it flat on the lined sheet. Each disc should end up about 6 mm thick.
8. Bake 7 minutes, turn the sheet around, and bake 7 minutes more, until the bottoms and the edges are golden brown.
9. Let them sit on the sheet 5 minutes, then move them to a wire rack.
10. Keep them in an airtight container at room temperature, where they hold a week.

NOTES

> Nothing in the dough is wheat. The structure comes from ground rolled oats plus oat flour, so these are gluten-free if the oats are certified.
> A tablespoon of dough per biscuit is what lands the yield at 24. Bigger discs will not bake through in 14 minutes.
> The butter goes in cold and is cut or rubbed only to a sandy stage, which is what keeps the texture flaky rather than solid.
> 300 g of rolled oats against 70 g of sugar puts these on the savory side of a sweet biscuit, and the teaspoon of salt is deliberate.
> About 10 of them, 150 g, crumble into a 23 cm gluten-free pie shell or a 25 cm cheesecake base.

DATE ___ / ___ / ___ RATING ___ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

NOTES _____

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